

interview of the week **NAWAZ SHARIF**

state-owned industries and banks were privatised.

Q. Would you agree if I say that the Pakistani politicians have failed their people?

A. No. It is the intervention of the military generals. Every now and then, there is a coup. Elected governments are toppled, ex-prime ministers are jailed or worse, hanged. That is a constant reminder to us that democracy is the only way out.

Q. Pakistan is often referred to as a failed state.

A. It's not a failed state. Frequent army takeovers and the interventions of generals have led to that impression. We can turn Pakistan back into a very successful state if the army is confined

signature on the document, is engaged in a dialogue with the Government, it's a matter of concern.

Q. Do you think the deal between Musharraf and Bhutto will last?

A. I don't know. But I think no party or person who believes in democracy should get into any dialogue with military dictators. They ruined our system. They have violated the Constitution. They are usurpers, traitors.

Q. But there is a certain bonhomie

the coup. They brought two papers with them and wanted me to sign them. One was about the dissolution of the National Assembly and the second paper was my resignation as prime minister. I refused to sign the papers and sent them away.

Q. How did you land up in Jeddah?

A. I'm grateful to the King and the Crown Prince of Saudi Arabia who thought of me in my difficult times.

Q. In the 60 years of Independent

"I don't want to serve under Musharraf. I am not interested in becoming another Shaukat Aziz. I have no desire to be Musharraf's dummy prime minister."



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Pakistan, generals have ruled it for nearly 35 years. What hope is there for your country?

A. That is why we insist that the Constitution be taken back to its position of October 12, 1999. I think this should be done because you can't let these people go scot free. They have to be punished. This can be done only with the people's support.

Q. When you go back to Pakistan you'll have to give up your ties and jackets? You can't do politics in Pakistan in this dress.

A. (Laughs) Don't I look good in this?

Q. You are looking good. You can be a great politician indeed if the people of Pakistan accept you.

A. I have been wearing salwar kameez and waistcoat for a long time. I'll try to wear both dresses this time if I get a chance.

Q. When do you plan to return to Pakistan?

A. I intend to go back before the elections.

Q. When will that be?

A. Things are very unpredictable at the moment. Even Musharraf doesn't know whether he is going to get elected in the current assembly or the next assembly. He doesn't know where the country is heading. I don't know where we are heading. But I believe I have a role to play and I'm playing that role.

to the barracks.

Q. Musharraf has been trying to divide your party. Benazir Bhutto, who was your ally a couple of months ago, is now in talks with him.

A. Musharraf has not been able to divide or create any dent in our vote-bank. We have won elections twice with thumping majority—once with two-third majority. Now we have signed a Charter of Democracy with Benazir Bhutto *sahiba*. It's clearly written in that charter that we would not enter into any parleys or deals with the Government. I stand by that.

Q. But Bhutto is in talks with the General.

A. If any party, which has put its

between them.

A. I don't think any such an arrangement will last.

Q. Were you ever approached on Musharraf's behalf?

A. He sent emissaries three times but I refused to meet them. I'm not interested in becoming another Shaukat Aziz. I don't want to serve under Musharraf. I don't want to be a dummy prime minister.

Q. But didn't you cut a deal with him when you were allowed to go to Saudi Arabia and that you will not interfere in Pakistan politics?

A. I never signed any agreement with Musharraf. His three army generals came to see me on the first day of

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